a curse of the unseasonal rain during harvest, dampening offtake. "The lower the procurement, the lesser the financial outflow in bonus payment," says a Mantralaya official who does not wish to be identified. "A host of welfare schemes announced ahead of the assembly polls are bleeding MP financially. Discouraging sale of wheat to the government will help conserve funds."

Farmers complain of a lag in payment compared to previous years, acting as another disincentive. Away from official circles, another explanation doing the rounds is of a dearth of enthusiasm among farmers for official procurement centres. Those who have loans due with state cooperative banks avoid selling their produce to the government as the loan amount is deducted from the sale proceeds. Instead, they sell to private traders.

At the end of last year, in its assembly election manifesto, the ruling BJP had promised to buy wheat at Rs 2,700 per quintal. When the new Mohan Yadav-led government took charge in February, it announced only a bonus of Rs 125 per quintal over the Rs 2,275 central MSP for wheat. The effective total—Rs 2,400—is well short of the promised amount, but the highest for any state, and perhaps proving too high for Madhya Pradesh. Despite the low procurement, the state's current stock is far in excess of the 1.6 MT wheat it requires annually under the public distribution system (PDS).

Where does this low procurement place Madhya Pradesh vis-a-vis other states? In the rabi season of 2020-21, it was India's top procurer, above Punjab and Haryana. This season, both states have overtaken it (see *The Grain Drain*). Punjab has surpassed its procurement of the previous year by 0.5 MT and Haryana by 0.8 MT. Even Uttar Pradesh, which procured only 0.21 MT last year, has procured 0.9 MT this time. All of which make Madhya Pradesh's underachievement even bleaker. ■

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LIQUOR CRISIS AIADMK leader Edappadi Palaniswami addresses the media on the hooch tragedy

TN HOOCH TRAGEDY

DEADLY SPIRIT

By Amarnath K. Menon

For eight years till 2019, Tamil Nadu seemed to have put the evil genie back into the bottle and screwed the cap back on. It recorded zero deaths from the consumption of illicit hooch during that span—call it a state of heightened vigil after 2011 saw an all-time high of 481 deaths from that cause. The worm on the graph had been slowly raising its head again, with 64 deaths in 2020-23. But 2024 has matched that in one shot, putting a district and town called Kallakurichi on the national map for all the wrong reasons. Tragedy struck on June 18 night, as scores taken ill by illegal hooch started queuing up at the local government hospital. By all accounts, a total of 225 people were admitted across various medical facilities in the state. Some were discharged, some were still being treated a week later, and many didn't make it. By June 26, the death toll had touched 63. The victims are mostly from Karunapuram, a predominantly Dalit village in Kallakurichi, which is itself often listed among the state's most backward areas.

The incident has stirred a political storm in Tamil Nadu—handing the Opposition, dispirited after an electoral drubbing in the recent Lok Sabha polls, an unexpected moral advantage over the ruling Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK). Calls for the resignation of chief minister M.K. Stalin, therefore, were ringing out with special fervour as he was blamed for failing to check the sale of spurious liquor. Members of the All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK), wearing black shirts to the assembly to register their protest, were suspended on June 25—initially